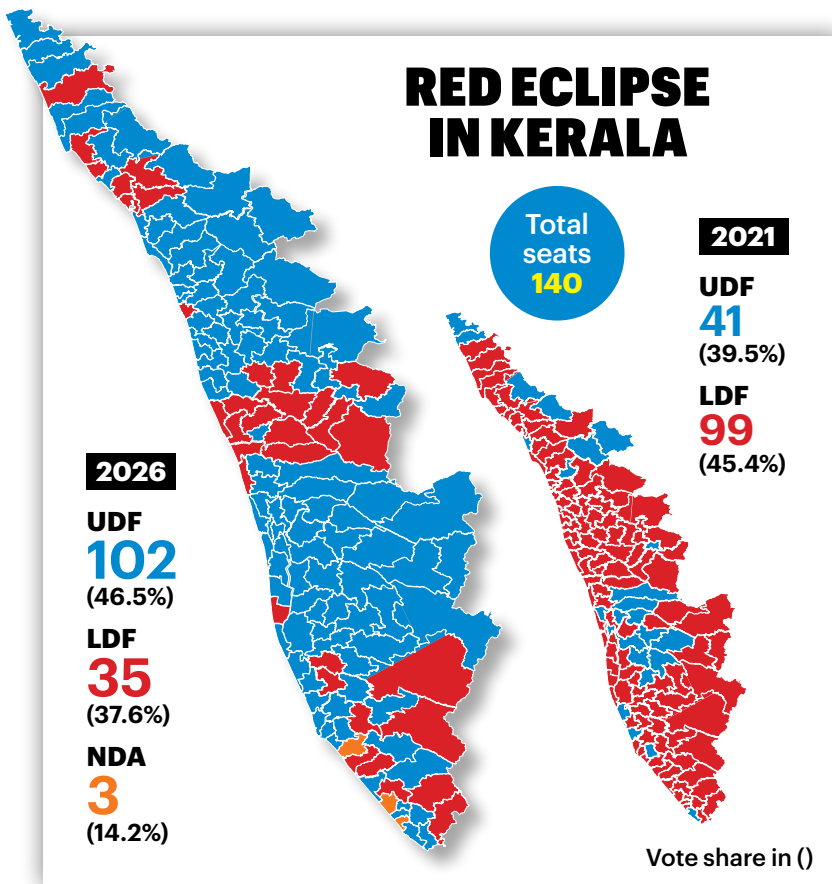
A running joke among Malayalis during the election campaign in Kerala was that you couldn't walk a kilometre anywhere in the state without a giant flex of the 'Great Leader'—the now-deposed chief minister Pinarayi Vijayan—peering down at you. In hindsight, perhaps not the best move for a party of the proletariat carrying the anti-incumbency baggage of a decade in power. At one of the post-victory press conferences, the Congress taunted that this personality cult and the "hubris" in the CPI(M) campaign slogan, '*Mattaarundu LDF allaathe* (If not the Left, who else?)' had done enough to convince voters that a change was needed.

The results speak for themselves—the Left Front is down to 35 seats from 99 in 2021, one of its worst defeats in over four decades, while the Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF) posted one of the highest tallies in recent Kerala political history, bagging 102 seats (46.5 per cent vote share) in the 140-member assembly. What changed? The return of the minority communities to the UDF and Congress this election, an 8.9 per cent swing in votes that has helped rout the Left even in its strongholds. The Congress has had one of its best showings in years, with 63 seats, followed by the Indian Union Muslim League (IUML) with 22, and the Kerala Congress (Joseph faction) with seven. Minor allies and UDF-backed independents cornered another 10 seats.

"We worked as 'Team UDF' in the past five years. And today, we made it," Leader of the Opposition in the outgoing assembly, V.D. Satheesan, tells INDIA TODAY. "When I said we'd win 100 plus seats, not many in my party believed me. But I was confident." The Congress leader says the party focused on four things—reconnecting with allies who had drifted away, drawing in sections who were disappointed with the Pinarayi government, boosting cadre morale after the 2021 assembly poll loss and exposing the Left Democratic Front government's failures.

The Congress focused on four things: reconnecting with estranged allies, pulling in sections unhappy with LDF rule, boosting cadre morale and exposing the failures of the Pinarayi Vijayan government



Indeed, Satheesan had worked tirelessly since 2021, when he was given the responsibility of Leader of the Opposition in the assembly. The weak party machinery, lack of funds for poll campaigns, factionalism in the state party organisation were handicaps, but what stood him in good stead was his staunchly secular credentials and refusal to back down from a fight, be it in the assembly against the Left Front, or outside it against caste/ religion-based political outfits. In fact, the secular stand helped him lance Pinarayi's soft Hindutva moves with Ezhava community leader Vellappally Natesan and Nair Service Society (NSS) supremo G. Sukumaran Nair. The Congress also backed the six CPI(M) rebels in the fray. Three of them won decisively.

The massive victory, though, does not mean Satheesan has emerged as sole claimant for the CM's post. A three-way tussle is on right now, with a group led by former PCC chief K. Sudhakaran campaigning for AICC general secretary K.C. Venugopal, even as Satheesan loyalists want him rewarded. Former Leader of